a FlexLifeFi K-12 program

What to Watch For at Home

One good question per quarter - no quizzing, no pressure.

Grade 9 year theme — Entrepreneurship Is Organized Problem-Solving.
The 9-12 band is built for the adults who will scrutinize: parents, teachers, administrators.

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Grade 9 · Parent Guide · the magazine version of the master document, set for adults to read end-to-end.

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GRADE 09 · PARENT GUIDE

What to Watch For Home

From flash of inspiration to repeatable discipline.

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A short, practical guide for the adult who lives with a Grade 9 Cash to Company student.

WITH CASH - 9-12 VOICE

"An MVP is the smallest test that could change your mind. It's not a v1."

What this year is

> "Profit is an opinion. Cash is a fact."
>
> - CASH, GRADE 9

This year, your student is learning to think like an entrepreneur — not by making money, but by paying attention with discipline. The big move of the year is **organized problem-solving**: turning a vague idea into a Business Model Canvas with evidence in every box, talking to five real customers, building a one-year P&L, and running a two-week test with a pre-committed metric for success.

Across the year, your student designs an **Organized Problem-Solving Venture** — a hypothetical (or sometimes real) business idea they sharpen through customer interviews, financial modeling, compliance work, and a 2-week MVP (minimum viable product) test. By June, they'll deliver a 7-minute defense of what they learned about a customer, a price, a number, and a recommendation: kill the idea, iterate, or scale it.

Most students do not start a real business this year. The point is not the business. The point is the moves: listening to people without leading them, modeling money honestly, naming compliance items, designing a small test, and changing your mind when evidence demands it.

This is the first year of the **9-12 high-school band** of Cash to Company. The vocabulary gets heavier (unit economics, runway, premortem, MVP, segmentation), the writing gets longer (multi-paragraph memos, 1-page P&Ls), and the questions get more direct. Cash, the program's mascot, now speaks in multi-sentence arguments at this band — "You'll meet adults who skipped this part and got lucky. Don't model your career on luck. Model it on the moves." That voice is intentional. We're building clearer thinkers, not making promises.

What your student is bringing home

You'll see:

- A **Capstone Journal** — the messy notebook where they sketch, plan, and reflect.
- A **Student Activity Book** — the structured workbook with Canvas templates, interview transcripts, P&L pages, compliance checklists, and reflection prompts.
- Occasional **Cash videos** to watch (2–3 minutes each) — short animated explainers from the program's mascot.
- An **interview script** — your student will do five real customer interviews. They may want to interview you. They have other options if not.
- A **1-year P&L** — likely a spreadsheet — showing revenue, costs, and net income for their imagined venture.
- A **compliance checklist** — license, sales tax, ID-required products, platform age limits, PII protection. Don't be surprised; this is part of the work.

They'll talk about their "Canvas," "positioning statement," "MVP," "unit economics," and "kill or iterate." If those terms feel new, that's fine — you don't need to know them. Your student will explain.

What you don't need to do

- **You don't need to know any of this.** A parent with no business background can fully support this curriculum.
- **You don't need to fund anything.** Capstones are educational. If your student wants to launch a real venture, that's a family decision and outside the curriculum's expectations.
- **You don't need to share your finances.** Curriculum-wide policy: no student is asked to share family financial details. If your student asks you a money question that feels invasive, redirect them — there's no homework that requires it.
- **You don't need to evaluate whether the business "would work."** Neither do panel evaluators at the Final Defense. The rubric measures evidence quality, financial reasoning, and reflection — not market viability.

What you can do (if you want)

> **"I don't know either. That's why we test."**
>
> - CASH, GRADE 9

These are optional and low-effort. None of them are required.

1. Ask one good question per quarter

Try one of these on a car ride or over dinner. Each question lines up with one of the four units.

- **Quarter 1 (September–November):** "What's the one assumption in your venture that, if it were wrong, would mean the whole thing doesn't work?"
- **Quarter 2 (November–January):** "What did one of your customers actually say in an interview that surprised you?"
- **Quarter 3 (January–March):** "What's the riskiest number on your P&L, and how would you check it?"
- **Quarter 4 (March–June):** "What was your two-week test result, and what did you decide — keep going, change something, or stop?"

You don't need to know the right answer. You're modeling curiosity, not expertise. The right reaction to most answers is "Tell me more about that."

2. Be a customer (if asked) — but don't be a cheerleader

Your student may ask to interview you. Treat it like a real interview — give them honest answers, including the boring parts. **The most useful thing you can do is not be a cheerleader.** "That's a great idea, honey" is what your student will get from any kind person. What they need from this curriculum is harder feedback: "I tried something like this last year and bounced off because of X. I'm not sure I'd pay for it."

If interviewing you doesn't feel right, it's fine to say so. There are alternatives — neighbors, teachers, extended family, online communities (with permission).

3. Talk about a small business you know

If you've ever started something small — a side service, a fundraiser, a club, a household project — your story is gold. Your student is learning that real ventures involve showing up, being wrong, and adjusting. The most useful thing you can share is what you got wrong and what you did about it.

If you haven't started anything like that, an aunt, neighbor, or friend who has is a great alternate source. The "founder origin story" is more useful at this age than the "founder success story."

AN INTERLUDE · GRADE 09

"Which people, and how do you know?"

the program's spine question.

1

Things to watch for

A pull to launch real

Grade 9 students are old enough to actually start a small venture. Some will want to. The curriculum supports this as a family decision, not as a curriculum requirement. The Capstone can be done entirely on paper and earn the highest grade. **If your student wants to launch real, three rules from the program:**

1. Complete the curriculum work first — Canvas v2, P&L, compliance checklist.
2. Have a family conversation about whether this is the right time, what the costs are, and who's responsible for what.
3. Pay attention to compliance: many states require a basic seller's permit and sales tax registration even for small ventures. The Unit 3 work walks your student through this.

Personal info on public platforms

The curriculum's compliance unit covers **PII** — personally identifiable information. If your student already has public social media or e-commerce accounts with their full name, school, photo, and city visible, that may come up in this unit. The curriculum doesn't ask anyone to delete an account; it does ask students to use initials in customer transcripts and to think carefully about what they post when running a business publicly. If a conversation about platform safety or privacy feels right at home, this is a useful prompt.

A "great idea" that needs you to spend money

Your student gets excited about a venture and wants you to fund supplies. Two responses both work:

- "What did your math say it would cost? What's the break-even volume? Show me your P&L." (Pulls them into the work.)
- "This sounds like a real-life version of the curriculum, not the class version. Let's talk about whether to do that." (Separates the curriculum from the family decision.)

Customer "interviews" that drift

A student says "I learned that Maya hates the cafeteria food." Coach: "That's a quote, but is it customer evidence? Did she say what she'd want instead? When did she last actually pay for something different? Would she pay you?" Anonymize what they bring home — the curriculum norm is to use only initials in transcripts.

Something that doesn't sit right ethically

If your student's venture leans toward exclusion, body-image messaging, age-restricted products, or anything else that pings you, mention it to the teacher. The curriculum has built-in pivot windows three times during the year for exactly this. Teachers welcome family flags.

Conversation starters (if you want)

- "Which Canvas box is riskiest in your venture right now?"
- "What's one quote from your interviews you'd put on a poster?"
- "What's your gross margin? What's that mean in your business?"
- "Walk me through your compliance checklist. What applies, and what doesn't?"
- "If your two-week test came back the opposite of what you predicted, what would you do?"
- "What's your default conflict-handling style? Is it the right one most of the time?"

Privacy and sensitivity

> **"Most adults skip this step. You won't."**
>
> - CASH, GRADE 9

The curriculum:

- Uses **fictional names** for personas, not classmates' real names.
- Asks students to use **initials only** in interview transcripts.
- Avoids **family financial details** entirely. No homework asks how much your family spends on anything.
- Uses **neutral hypothetical scenarios** ("for a sample venture," "for a hypothetical 16-year-old") for any general money examples.
- Treats **compliance as logistics, not ethics.** A teen who didn't know about sales tax isn't a bad person; they're a person who hasn't read the form yet. The curriculum teaches the form.

If something feels off, contact the teacher. The teacher can adjust assignments, swap ventures, or modify pacing for any reason — including a flag from a caregiver.

A note about success this year

A "successful" Grade 9 Cash to Company student does not necessarily start a business, make money, or impress a panel. A successful student:

- Mapped a Business Model Canvas with honest evidence-or-flag in every box.
- Talked to five real customers without leading them.
- Built a 1-year P&L they can defend.
- Ran a 2-week MVP test with a pre-committed success metric.
- Made — and defended — a kill, iterate, or scale recommendation.
- Wrote, at the end of the year, "the biggest thing I got wrong on Day 1 was..."

If you see those six things on the kitchen table over the year, the program worked.

AN INTERLUDE · GRADE 09

"Most adults skip the step. You won't."

the band's working assumption.

2

Questions?

Your student's teacher is the first stop for any question about the curriculum. They can also send home longer-form materials (the full Curriculum Book, the Lesson Plans) if you'd like a deeper look.

Thank you for being part of this. The biggest predictor of whether a financial-thinking habit sticks is whether it's also alive at home — even at the level of one curious question per quarter.

— The Cash to Company team

Senior expert upgrade pack — "Whose money is at risk?" dinner-table script

> **"An MVP is the smallest test that could change your mind. It's not a v1."**
>
> - CASH, GRADE 9

If your Grade 9 child comes home and says "I want to start a real business — can you help me with $200 for supplies?" — this is the script:

You: "Tell me your BMC. Just the customer box and the value-prop box."

Child: (answers)

You: "How many real customer interviews have you done?"

Child: (answers — should be at least 5 by mid-year)

You: "What's the smallest test you could run for less than $20?"

Child: (thinks; this is the MVP question)

You: "Whose money is at risk in this venture? Yours, mine, or both?"

Child: (answers)

You: "If we lost the $200, would the lesson be worth it? Or should we run the smaller test first?"

End. You haven't said yes or no. You've asked the questions a real venture investor asks. The decision belongs to your family. The lesson is the questions themselves.

Other one-question prompts

- "Which of your BMC boxes is most likely to be wrong?"
- "What's your gross margin look like?"
- "What would the smallest version of this look like?"
- "Which of these compliance items applies to your venture?"

You don't need to know what gross margin means. The kid does. You just have to ask.

ROUND 2 PATCH — Three 30-Second Conversation Starters per Quarter (Grade 9)

Quarter 1 (BMC + Customer Discovery) 1. At dinner: "Whats one box on your BMC that has the least evidence?" — Follow-up: "How would you get evidence?" 2. Drive-time: "Did you talk to a customer this week? What did they actually say?" — Follow-up: "Did anything surprise you?" 3. In a coffee shop: "Lets sketch this places BMC in our heads. Customer? Value prop? Channels? Revenue?" — Follow-up: "Where do you think their gaps are?"

Quarter 2 (P&L + MVP Test) 1. Drive-time: "Whats your ventures revenue? COGS? Gross margin?" — Follow-up: "Would you walk me through it?" 2. At dinner: "Whats your MVP test? What would have to be true for you to be right?" — Follow-up: "What would have to be true for you to be wrong?" 3. Watching news: "This company shut down — what assumption do you think broke?" — Follow-up: "How would youve tested it?"

Quarter 3 (Compliance + Contracts)

If your child has a venture and wants to make it real:

- "Do you need a license? Sales tax registration?"
- "Do you have a one-page service agreement?"
- "Whos the customer, what are they paying, when, and what happens if they dont?"

If your child cant answer all four, the venture isnt ready for real money yet. Coach back to the contracts lesson.

Quarter 4 ("Whose money is at risk?" Dinner-Table Script)

If your child wants to spend $50+ on the venture:

- **You:** "Whose money is at risk?"

- **Child:** "Mine."
- **You:** "What if it doesnt work?"
- **Child:** "I lose the $50."
- **You:** "Are you okay with that?"
- **Child:** "Yes."
- **You:** "Then go. If you need to borrow, lets talk about terms first — interest rate, repayment plan, what happens if we lose it."

This script teaches the kid to think like a founder borrowing capital. The terms conversation is the lesson, not the loan itself.

> **SENSITIVITY**
> This script does not require parents to actually fund the venture. The conversation works either way.

ROUND 2 PATCH — What Cash Never Says (Parent Reference)

Cash will never say: "Amazing!" / "Everyone can be rich" / "Easy money" / "Passive income" / "Just believe in yourself" (as substitute for evidence) / anything implying money problems are a personal failing.

Cash always asks: "Which people, and how do you know?" / "Whats the evidence?"

Why this matters at home. Your child will encounter financial-literacy content from many sources, some hustle-bro coded. The contrast is the point. Cash is on your familys side.

One question this year: "What would have to be true for your venture to be wrong? How would you know?"

ENDNOTES & STANDARDS

Citations and alignment

Grade 9 cites 3-6 standards across CCSS, Jump$tart, CEE, CASEL, and C3 frameworks. Detailed alignment lives in the master Standards Alignment Map.

1. **Jump$tart Coalition Personal Finance Standards (2021 ed.).** Spending and Saving; Credit and Debt; Employment and Income; Investing; Risk Management and Insurance; Financial Decision Making.
2. **Council for Economic Education (CEE).** Voluntary National Content Standards in Economics.
3. **CCSS-ELA, Grades 11-12.** W.11-12.1, W.11-12.4, SL.11-12.1, SL.11-12.4, RST.11-12.7.
4. **CCSS-Math.** N-Q.1-3 (Reasoning with Quantities), S-IC (Statistics & Inferences), F-IF (Functions), MP.4 (Modeling).
5. **CASEL Core Competencies.** Self-Awareness, Self-Management, Social Awareness, Relationship Skills, Responsible Decision-Making.
6. **C3 Framework for Social Studies State Standards.** Dimension 2 (Economics, Civics) at the high-school grade band.
7. **NGSS-ETS Engineering Practices.** ETS1 (Engineering Design) for the test-and-iterate spine of the year.
8. **Cash to Company Master Scope & Sequence.** 13 grades x 8 strands x 36 weeks; outcomes quoted verbatim from _master/00_Master_Scope_and_Sequence.md.
9. **Cash Mascot Style Guide.** 9-12 voice rules: multi-sentence arguments; vocabulary includes unit economics, runway, premortem, MVP; never flatters, never promises wealth.
10. **Sensitivity protocol.** No probing of family finances; financial scenarios framed as hypothetical for a sample household, business, or scenario.

One promise.

Cash to Company makes one promise: students who move t
program will be clearer thinkers about money and entrepren
matter what they end up doing for a living.

We do not promise wealth. We do not promise success. We pro

> **“From flash of inspiration to repeatable discipline.”**

- CASH, GRADE 9

For educational use. This curriculum is informational and does not constitute financial, legal, or tax advice. Standards alignment cited per the Cash to Company Standards Alignment Map (Jump$tart, CEE, CCSS, C3, CASEL, NGSS-ETS).